

CHAPTER TWO

The Teenage Period

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PART ONE

I was ordained a Deacon in the Aaronic Priesthood on my birthday, April 1, 1934 by my Bishop, Louis F. Nuffer. Later when I was in high school he was also my biology teacher. Passing the sacrament in those days was a stiffly formal affair. We all had to wear white shirts and black bow ties and always held our left arm behind our backs. The trays were much heavier than they are now and contained small real glasses which had to be washed after each Sunday. Our family used to have the job of cleaning these glasses and trays every week. During these years, I used to give frequent two-and-a half minute talks which were standard for the Sunday School up until about the early 1980's and afforded the youth a great opportunity to learn to speak before a congregation. I always performed pretty well on these talks and received a lot of compliments.

My ordination to the office of a Teacher took place on November 15, 1936 by Vern L. Brown, a member of the bishopric of the fourth ward. I participated in several things of interest during these early teen-age years. One was a excursion to the Logan Temple to do proxy baptisms. On our way home we stopped at the grave site of Martin Harris, my great grandfather in Clarkston, Utah, the same town where my father, Lehi, was born. We also stopped at the mineral springs at Soda Springs, Idaho and enjoyed the activities there. I also played on the ward volley-ball team that went to Salt Lake City for some sort of finals - we didn't win, that much I recall, but we had a good time just the same. I was also a Boy Scout. My Boy Scout activities were all right but not great. I reached the rank of Star and basically lost interest since I had to work so much after school. I went on several scout trips to Yellowstone Park and other areas in Idaho which had beautiful lakes, rivers, and streams, great for fishing.

On one occasion someone's axe slipped just as I walked by and cut deep into my right foot just below the ankle. This eliminated my going on the traditional fourteen mile hike so I stayed in camp and fished all day, catching enough fish to feed the whole troop that night. On another trip Martin and I slept on the truck bed instead of on the ground and had the experience of having a bear, which was scrounging for food in the camp, put its paws right up close to us on the truck bed while we held our breath until it decided to search somewhere else.

I think that it was during my freshman year in High School that I went to work after school at Brandl's Meat Market. From Monday to Friday, I worked from 4:00 P.M. to

'6:00 P.M. and all day on Saturdays from about 9:00 A.M. to 9:00 P.M. My pay was \$2.00 per week plus a few pounds of meat for the family. I was always paid in silver dollars. On occasion I would go to a late movie which cost about 10 cents in those days. Most of the time I was too tired and only wanted to get home to rest. The meat I received was the only meat that the family ever got so it was a very special occasion to us. My work consisted of cleaning chickens and preparing them for the counters, using the cube-steak machine, cleaning up the cutting room as well as helping put the counter meat back into the refrigerated lockers after the close of business. This work I did until school was over in the Spring.

I then quit and went to work out on a farm belonging to Wiley Snarr, a member of our Ward. I milked cows twice per day and helped with the hay, irrigation and all the other various tasks associated with farm work. I slept in the bunk house. The only pay I received was board and room (however, the food was the best that I had ever eaten) and at the end of the summer a supply of coal for our fuel in the house. Wiley and I went to the Blind Bull coal mine to pick up the coal and I had the opportunity of going into the mine. This was the first time that I had ever been inside a mine and I have never experienced such utter blackness in my life. Working that summer on the farm convinced me that I never wanted to be a farmer. The hours and frustration would be just too much for me.

I attended Riverside grammar school (formerly Eagle Rock which was the original name for Idaho Falls) for my 5th and 6th years. This school was not as prestigious as the one I attended previously i.e. Eastside. After grammar school I went to O. E. Bell Jr. High for the 7th, 8th and 9th years of schooling. Sometime during this period, either after the 7th or 8th grades, Mother decided to move to Salt Lake City which apparently was an ill-fated venture and didn't last very long because we returned to Idaho Falls for the next year of school. I went to Idaho Falls High for my sophomore year (1937/38) and delivered the Salt Lake Tribune, a morning newspaper, getting up about 4:00 A.M. since it was a long route taking me across town on my bicycle. The winter months in Idaho Falls were pretty vicious and I recall taking some bad spills on icy pavement and railroad tracks with a load of newspapers. Also, there was always the problems of dogs yapping at your feet as you pedaled along. In some areas I had to carry a squirt gun with ammonia in it to ward the dogs off. Just a few weeks before school was out I contracted the mumps and didn't have to finish the year out since my grades were good enough that I was just given credit for the term.

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Following my recovery I went to California to live with my sister Loverna and her husband Al (Lester Allan Harris). They lived in Pomona, California where they had rented a house which had some grape arbors and chicken coops which had been flooded. In the summer I worked primarily at cleaning out the chicken coops which had a layer of about four inches of silt from the flood that had hit that area the previous year. It was hard work but eventually we got enough coops cleaned out so that Al could buy some young chicks which he planned to raise for eggs and/or fryers. He borrowed some money to buy the chicks and we attempted to raise them with little success. They all eventually died and Al had to figure out how to pay back the money he had borrowed. We sold the Concord grapes that were raised in the arbor but Al couldn't afford the rent on the house so we took a couple of rooms at a hotel.

For a while Al had a pretty good job working in a bakery but he was fired from that for engaging in union-organizing activity (there was no protection for such activity as there is now). I didn't really know what was going on at that time since I had never heard much about labor problems but obviously we were engaged in some activity which, at that time, was probably illegal, or at least not protected by the law. I know on several occasions I helped Al and some of his associates to pass out union literature in certain neighborhoods and we had to take all sorts of precautions against getting caught.

Al Harris was a difficult person to like. He was small in stature but claimed to have been a flyweight fighter at one time. He drank a lot and talked a lot about all the things he was going to accomplish but none ever came to fruition. It was pretty tough on me. I was trying to go to High School and yet help out as much as I could to pay for my room and board. I swept out the union halls after school and went with Al on another venture of his, i.e. selling lunches to workers on construction sites. I think some of the things Al engaged in could have been successful had Al had the business background and a little humility. He wouldn't take much advice from anyone and was always getting stung. He and Loverna had just been married a year and didn't as yet have any children so from that standpoint it was fortunate. Loverna was pretty supportive of Al but they did have some heated arguments over his ventures.

In retrospect, my year in Pomona, California was useful to me in that I found new friends and, for the first time, formulated a desire to go to college. The school I attended was Pomona High School and Jr. College, basically a fourteen year arrangement. A student could just continue right on into Jr. College there without missing a beat, not

even changing school locations. I was a good student and was able to engage in quite a few extra-curricular activities such as debating and extemporaneous speaking which involved traveling around to other high schools in the area for debate meets. My fellow students, particularly those on the debate team, accepted me and we did a lot of fun things together. Although I never had any formal dates, I participated in a lot of group activities.

After the first semester I was elected to the honor society which was called the Thaliens and, amongst other things, being in that group got out of taking final exams. Instead, the membership had a year-end outing at Balboa Beach. My history/civics teacher was quite concerned that I wasn't planning to go on to college (I still had a year of high school to complete) and said for me to try to remain in California and take advantage of its junior college program. Of course, this was impossible. I felt that I had imposed enough on Al and Loverna and was just another worry for them. In school I belonged to the Indaba Club as well as the Thaliens. Indaba was a forensic organization organized to further student interest in speech arts. The word "Indaba" is of African origin and has something to do with big words. My closest friends in my Junior year were all members of the debate team, Chuck Vander Linden, Shirley Tyson, and Nancy Simonsen.

In addition to my school activities I was active in the local ward of the church and made a lot of good friends there as well as participating in the usual Church social activities. One of the friends of that time was named Forrest Black. Later we both were at BYU together and his son Daryl married my niece Lyndel (one of Loverna and Al's children). Getting back to Idaho Falls was a problem after the school year finished. Al and Loverna couldn't afford to send me back by train or bus (that kind of travel was very sporadic in those days anyhow.) I finally ended up riding with a couple in a Model A Ford. This was before the days of air-conditioned cars so it was pretty hot traveling across the desert. Cars usually carried a water bag made of tough canvas which was hung on a headlight or grill ornament and the evaporation kept the water fairly cool and served for refreshment or, more often than not, to put into the radiator which usually overheated.

One of the big surprises that I encountered upon my return to Idaho Falls was the growth of my good friend, Jack Kelley, who was about my height when I left but was a tall 6'5" kid when I returned. Jack, Reuel Nielson and I were always a three-some although Jack was a year older than Reuel and I. We did practically everything together from about the 7th or 8th grade on. Some other friends during my Jr. High and High school years were Wilmer Norton, Harold Price and his brother, Rulon, and Melvin Olsen (whom we

called Pasca for no particular reason). Jack always wanted to me a radio announcer and Reuel (whom we called Jr. because his Dad was also a Reuel) was constantly fiddling with electronic gadgets. Jack's dad was a manufacturers' representative and Jr.'s owned and operated the Riteway hardware store in Idaho Falls for many years.

Since I had spent my Junior year in Pomona, I returned to Idaho Falls High as a transfer student and didn't belong to any clubs or participate in any of the school offices during my Senior year. I again delivered the Salt Lake Tribune in the early morning hours

Prior to the start of school the whole family went up to Victor, Idaho to work at picking the fall crop of peas. While it was a lot of hard work, it was a very picturesque place to be, right at the base of the Teton mountains. There were some excellent trout streams in the area and even a warm springs where one could go swimming. We used to stun the fish in the shallow streams with our flippers.

About this time I was ordained to the office of a Priest on September 24, 1939 by Jack A. Packer, a member of the 4th Ward bishopric.

The years 1939-1940, of course were critical and crucial ones in the history of the world. Upon my graduation from high school in May 1940, the only thing anybody talked about was as to when the U.S. would be joining in the war effort. The plans of most young people were at best very tentative. Of course, I would have gladly gone to college had the opportunity presented itself. In September 1939, World War II began with Germany's invasion of Poland and the declaration of war by Great Britain and France. By the time of my graduation Germany had invaded Belgium, The Netherlands, and Luxembourg. I remember my mother's tears and concern when it was reported (erroneously) that the Nazi's had also invaded Switzerland. This never happened since it was important to have a neutral state in the area.

Just after graduation, a group of us took a trip to the World's Fair in San Francisco on Treasure Island. We used the Oldsmobile of Reuel's dad and the other members of the group beside Reuel and myself were Jack Kelley and Melvin Olsen. As a historical note the featured speaker at this fair was an up and coming politician who had just been elected Governor of Minnesota, Harold Stassen, and whom many were predicting would become the president of the United States. As of 1988 he's still trying!

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Unable to find a job in Idaho Falls, Jack Kelley and I hitch-hiked to Salt Lake City. I had a recommendation

from our Stake President ,Heber Austin ,and was able to get employment in the Presiding Bishop's office as a clerk-typist. Jack eventually got a job type-setting at the Deseret News. We lived initially in a small hotel on Main St. (for \$2.00 per week) and usually ate at the Grabeteria , a little standup hole in the wall for fast food. Later we moved to the Wilson Hotel and ultimately to a boarding house across the street from the 12th Ward chapel. Here we remained until Jack got transferred and I got married to Joyce McNeill.

My responsibilities at the PBO were exclusively clerical in nature, typing out membership records, filing a copy and sending an appropriate copy to the Ward where a particular member resided. I was also almost exclusively responsible for the filing of the data for the LDS church census as it came in for the year 1940. As I recall the membership was around 800,000 at that time. I worked in this office at very minimum wages until an opportunity came to get a job with the Salt Lake City office of Western Electric Co, a Bell Telephone subsidiary, under the auspices of Mountain States Telephone and Telegraph. During the entire time of my employment there, I worked in the old Hyland Office of M.S.T. & T. This office was no longer functioning as a telephone exchange. The employees consisted of approximately 20/30 young men charged with the responsibility of dismantling the equipment of the exchange (a manual one) , since Salt Lake was gradually switching to a dial system.

Almost immediately upon my assignment, after a few days of slinging solder at terminal connections, I was asked to assume the responsibility for the time and attendance records, social security information, and collection of union dues for the CWA (Communications Workers of America). I guess I was given this job because I was good at math, had just come from a job with clerical and typing responsibilities and the boss (called the Installer in Charge) who had to do it himself before I came hated this kind of work. I also had to learn all there was to know about the telephone equipment at the office since the crew was involved in disconnecting and packaging it for shipment to other offices in the MST&T area.

I was involved in church activities as well and started to date a young woman named Joyce McNeill quite regularly in the summer of 1941. The war picture also continued to darken. U. S. Lend Lease was providing all our aid to Britain and other countries at war with the Axis powers (Germany, Italy and Japan). It just seemed a matter of time before the U.S. became an active participant in the war. In August 1941 , the Atlantic Charter was signed by Roosevelt and Churchill. On Dec. 7, 1941 Japan attacked the U. S. naval bases at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, destroying most

of the U.S. Pacific fleet. I was loafing at the boarding house between Sunday school and sacrament meeting when the radio announced the attack on Pearl Harbor. The next day Japanese troops attacked the Philippines, Hongkong, Thailand and British Malaya and the U.S. and Great Britain declared war on Japan. By Dec. 11, Germany and Italy declared war on the U.S. and Congress recognized a state of war with these two nations as well as with Japan. Immediately with these events, our work force began to disintegrate. The Installer In Charge joined the Navy and, because of my knowledge of all the procedures, as well as the equipment, I was given his responsibility which corresponded to the work of a foreman. Pretty heady stuff for a young man just 19 years old.

From the outset of my employment with Western Electric I made it a point to maintain good relations with the secretary of my boss, a crusty old telephone man named T.J. Hurley, in the main office. My friendship with her paid off in spades. She would advise me candidly when my boss was upset about something (usually a shipment that hadn't arrived at the designated destination on time or a delay on our part in making the shipment). There was very little of this but when it did happen sparks flew from the main office. Having been forewarned as to what the problem was, I usually was able to find out what happened by the time the boss got to our office (which didn't take him very long.) More often than not it involved the newness of the employee. My crew changed almost weekly due to the draft situation.

Having been given a raise in pay because of my status as the Installer In Charge (as I recall from about \$22.50 per week to \$27.50) I felt I could afford to pop the question to Joyce McNeill. Eventually she accepted (she was still only 17 but looked and acted much more mature) although her mother was never really in favor of our marriage. I was ordained an Elder on 24th of May 1942 by Elwood Heiner, the President of the 4th Quorum of Elders of the Emigration Stake. At any rate we were married in the Salt Lake temple on 30 September 1942 and less than a month later I received my draft notice. I had to decide whether to be a private in the Army or take a rating in the Navy. Reuel Neilson had written me that anyone who could pass a basic exam in electronics could get a Radio Technician Third Class rating (about the equivalent of an Army buck sargeant) so I took this route and enlisted in the Navy as of October 23, 1942. More about my military service later, however. Almost as soon as I left for basic training at Treasure Island in San Francisco, Joyce's mother went to work on her. Her mother was on her second marriage herself and didn't have any qualms about breaking one up. We spent the twelve weeks of my training assignment at Utah State Agricultural College together since married sailors were given permission to have their wives there. After being at Logan, I was

assigned to the Corpus Christi Naval Air Base training school for training in advanced aviation radar. I received word that Joyce had miscarried and took a rush trip to Salt Lake City although there was nothing that I could do. Just prior to my departure from the six month training course at Corpus Christi (Oct.1943) Joyce wrote me that she wanted a divorce. Things sort of dragged for awhile and it wasn't until I had been assigned to Quonset Pt. Rhode Island Air Station, awaiting the completion of my ship that we did anything further about the divorce. By then after much prayer and meditation, I had pretty well concluded that it was in the best interest of both of us to shed this marriage. The divorce decree was dated Dec. 23, 1943.

It wasn't until I had been transferred to the U.S.S.Wasp and was at sea that the divorce and subsequent cancellation of our Temple sealing was finalized. I only saw Joyce once after that. I met her on a Salt Lake street while I was there on leave in 1945 following the bombing of the U.S.S.Wasp and our return to the States for repairs. She had married the sailor she knew before she met me. I hesitate to guess what my life would have been like had I remained married to Joyce. Perhaps, just have returned to Salt Lake and gone back to work for Western Electric. Who knows? As for Joyce, all I've heard through the Ila Rose grapevine is that she is currently (1988) on her fourth marriage.